

1 The Tengwar

Phi can be written in either of two ways: using the standard Latin alphabet or the Tengwar script. Tengwar was invented by J. R. R. Tolkien and first described in Appendix E of the third book in his trilogy, *The Lord of the Rings*. There are numerous sources of information available concerning the Tengwar so details and history of the script will not be explored in this document.

The look and feel of the Tengwar characters (*tengwa*) and its diacritical marks (*tehta*) match the ideals and philosophies behind this language. Phi has a small set of consonants and vowels so it is relatively straightforward to map its graphemes to Tengwar characters. The Unicode font *Tengwar Telcontar*¹ is used in this manual to render Phi text in Tengwar script. A custom keyboard layout² was employed to facilitate typing the Tengwar characters.

Tables 3 and 4 outline the mapping between the graphemes used in Phi and the corresponding Tengwar characters, as well as the keypresses necessary to produce the characters using the font and the keyboard layout mentioned previously. An application or utility that supports Graphite fonts³ is required for the font to render correctly. Experiments indicate that LibreOffice Writer v7.1.2.2 renders Tengwar Telcontar properly. A link to details of this requirement can be found in the first footnote below.

Written Phi uses the Tengwar's Quenya mode. Vowel diacriticals are placed on the consonant that precedes the vowel. Since all Phi words start with a consonant, there is never a need to use an initial vowel carrier. Words in Phi often contain two consecutive vowels, but a vowel carrier is still unnecessary: the second vowel is placed below the same consonant. The letters would then be read as consonant, upper vowel, then lower vowel. This and the use of a single Tengwar character for consonant doubles such as ph or sh cause Phi script to be very compact and efficient.

¹<http://freetengwar.sourceforge.net/tengtelc.html>

²<http://freetengwar.sourceforge.net/keylayouts.html>

³https://scripts.sil.org/cms/scripts/page.php?site_id=projects&item_id=graphite_fonts

The Phi word for “love” is *lothea*. In the Tengwar script it looks like this:



This six-letter word in latin characters requires only two *tengwa* to represent it. Many words in Phi are two to three letters long. This occurs mainly in parts of speech such as particles, prepositions, or pronouns. These words are almost always a single *tengwa* with diacriticals in Tengwar script. All of this results in a very concise writing system.

This is the phrase “I love you” in its simplest vernacular form in Phi:



That is a beautiful sentiment rendered in a beautiful script. In more formal communication in Phi, particles are used to mark parts of speech in order to reduce ambiguity. As well, word markers are often used to distinguish multisyllabic words for clarity. The Phi Tengwar punctuation is outlined in Table 5. As an example, the phrase “I love you” would be written formally as:



Table 1: Phi consonant grapheme to Tengwar mapping

	Front	Central	Back
Close	i		
Mid	ɛ		ɔ
Open		ä	